

VEHICLE CONDITION

No person shall operate or park a vehicle on public highways unless it has been inspected at least once a year, but that does not mean it is the only time you should have safety equipment checked. Follow your owner's manual for routine maintenance. Have problems corrected by a qualified mechanic as soon as possible. Do not wait until mechanical problems cause breakdowns or crashes.

Pay special attention to the maintenance and repair of the brakes, steering mechanism, lights, tires and horn. Depend on your owner manual and an experienced mechanic as keys to a safe vehicle. It is the operator's responsibility to ensure that the vehicle being driven is safe.

Here are some common problems, and some equipment checks you can do:

BRAKES - Brakes that pull to one side may be wet or may need to be adjusted or repaired. If wet, you can dry them riding the pedal lightly. If this does not help, have your brakes checked by a mechanic. If you notice any change in the brake performance, have them checked immediately.

STEERING - There should not be much free movement in the steering wheel. If your vehicle has power steering, check the fluid level periodically. A noise like a whine when you make a sharp turn can indicate a problem.

LIGHTS - Keep your lights clean and free of dirt, snow and ice. Broken lenses can cause dangerous glare for other drivers, so replace them as soon as you can. Make sure headlights are adjusted correctly to give you the best view of the road.

TIRES - The law requires that your tires have at least $\frac{2}{32}$ nds of an inch (.16 cm) of tread. Most tires for passenger cars and light trucks have indicators called "wear bars" that show across the tire grooves when the minimum tread depth is reached. You can check your tread depth with a penny. Hold a penny with Abraham Lincoln's body between your thumb and forefinger. Place Lincoln's head first into the deepest looking groove. Can you see all of his head? If yes, your tires are too worn – don't drive on them, and make sure to get them replaced. It is also illegal to drive with

tires that have cuts down to the cords, bumps or bulges. Refer to your owner manual or a tire store about correct tire pressure, and check it often with a reliable gauge.

GLASS - Keep your indows clean and clear. Replace worn wiper blades. Keep your defroster and rear window defogger in good condition and make sure there is enough windshield fluid in the reservoir.

HORN - Your horn is important safety equipment that could become your only means of warning other drivers or pedestrians of possible problems. If the horn does not work, get it repaired as soon as possible. It should be used properly, not to express anger at other drivers or pedestrians.

QUESTIONS

Before you move on to Chapter 9, make sure you can answer these questions:

- Should you always look straight ahead when you drive?
- If there is no posted speed limit, what is the fastest you can legally drive in New York City?
- Is it always safe to drive at the assigned speed limit?
- What is the purpose of minimum speed limits?
- Who must wear seat belts? Who should wear them?
- How can you prevent fatigue on a long trip?
- What is road rage? How can you prevent becoming involved in road rage?
- How should you drive safely through a work zone? A roundabout?